Ensuring Water for All

‘Jal Shakti Abhiyan: Catch the Rain’ campaign, which was launched with the aim of increasing decentralized water conservation with peoples’ participation, has gained momentum across the country



Exactly a year ago, on World Water Day, 22, March 2021, PM Modi launched the “Jal Shakti Abhiyan: Catch The Rain” (JSA:CTR) campaign, with the theme “Catch the rain, where it falls, when it falls”, about which he had alluded in his Mann-ki-Baat on 28-February, 2021. The very successful campaign under National Water Mission (NWM) was instrumental in creating over 47 lakh rain water harvesting structures (RWHS). This would have storied huge quantity of rain-water, which will hopefully ameliorate water woes across the country, in the ensuing summer.

This unique campaign, by converging funds of all water conservation related schemes- (MNREGA, AMRUT, CAMPA funds etc) of Central and State governments, funds mobilized locally and from corporate sectors, was to create and maintain RWHS, with total participation of people. JSA:CTR campaign had **five** focused interventions-*(a) rainwater harvesting & water conservation (b) enumerating, geo-tagging & making inventory of all water bodies; preparation of scientific plans for water conservation (c) Setting up Jal Shakti Kendras in all districts (d) intensive afforestation and (e) awareness generation*

Building upon the “Catch the Rain campaign” campaign initiated by NWM in 2020, which due to the restrictions imposed by Covid 19 pandemic mainly focused in government and private institutions with large land tracts, the JSA:CTR was launched by the PM in a function in New Delhi, in which he addressed DMs/ DCs of all districts and Sarpanchs of Gram Panchayats (GPs) of all States (except those where model code of conduct was in place) via Video Conferencing. He also interacted with 5 Sarpanchs, one each from Maharashtra, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Gujarat and Uttarakhand. This was followed by special Gram Sabhas held in all GPs in which issues related to water and its conservation was discussed and “Jal Shapath” taken by people. With a total of 2.69 lakh GPs in the country and on an average 50 people attending each Gram sabha, this could well be one of the biggest ever launch in the world of a water conservation campaign. PM wrote letters to all Sarpanchs to motivate them to take lead in this campaign.

Since its launch on 22 March,2021, till 31 December,2021, the end of campaign period, in urban, rural and forest areas put together, a whopping 46,70,271 water related works were completed/taken up, in addition to 36Cr afforestation activities carried out under the campaign. The expenditure under MNREGS alone was Rs 65,666 crores, in addition to the funds spent from AMRUT in urban areas and Finance commission grants in GPs. 2.03 lakh GPs have prepared scientific water conservation plans. This was the 1st campaign in which all areas – rural, urban and forest- of the country concurrently co-operated to catch and store rainwater.

Weekly reports were captured from the field in the portal *(http://jsactr.mowr.gov.in/)*. It was also used to make an inventory of all water bodies in the country, geo-tagged with photos, latitudes-longitudes information and its health status. The portal has over 16 lakh photos of the works done and information of 15 lakh water bodies.

The responsibility of implementing and monitoring of this herculean water conservation effort of the government was with G. Asok Kumar,Mission Director, NWM, during the campaign period, who rightly earned a moniker of “Rain man” for his sustained efforts to catch the rain. NWM collaborated with 9 central ministries/departments and all state governments for the implementation of this campaign.

Earlier NYKS and its youth clubs engaged with over 2.50 crore people to generate awareness about the campaign with their activities like rallies, Jal Choupals, quizzes, debates, slogan writing competitions, wall writings etc. NWM held 150+ webinars, Water-Talks,Water-Tech-Talks, “Dialogues with DMs” etc with experts, academicians etc for awareness generation & capacity building. It also engaged with universities and education institutions like IIM, IITs etc, Industry associations like FICCI and CII, NGOs and INGOs.10K+ bank branches displayed the campaign posters and promoted it in social media.

Rise in water-table across the country due to the successful implementation of the “Catch-the-Rain” campaign is acknowledged by those monitor it. The dream of a “Tanker Mukth Bharat” maybe a bit more closer to reality!